WARNING SIGNALS

Manipur is now split on ethnic lines—Naga, Kuki and Meitei—with all three sides competing for land and a share of power



FRAUGHT TIMES CM Khemchand Singh chairs a security coordination meeting in Imphal on September 17

- **February violence at Litan, followed by the May ambush of three Kuki-Zo church leaders and subsequent killing of six kidnapped Nagas widens the conflict rapidly**
- **Real battle is over land. Naga groups say Kuki settlements and infra projects such as Tiger-German road encroach on ancestral land**
- **Demand for a separate Kuki-Zo administration has revived old fears. Nagas worry that any new territorial deal may include 'their land'**
- **1990s wounds haven't healed. Over 700 killed in earlier Naga-Kuki conflict**
- **Naga and Meitei groups demand an NRC before Census, arguing that illegal migrants from Myanmar could distort population figures**
- **Kuki-Zo say Indian citizens are being clubbed with refugees, illegal migrants, armed groups and poppy cultivators**
- **40 of Manipur's 60 assembly seats are in the valley, 20 in the hills. Census data will be a battle over political power**

The killings widened the conflict. What had largely been friction involving Tangkhul Nagas and Kuki settlements around Ukhrul now drew Zeliangrong Nagas and areas of Senapati, Noney, Tamenglong and Kangpokpi. Very soon, roads were blocked and villages separated along ethnic lines. Manipur's ethnic partition is now no longer simply a valley versus hills issue; the hills themselves are being partitioned.

THE NRC CONUNDRUM

Meanwhile, after massive protests, the Centre has deferred the house-listing phase of Census 2027, scheduled to begin across Manipur in September. The sentiment was captured in a slogan that appeared across the Imphal Valley and Naga areas, 'No NRC, No Census'. Meitei and Naga organisations want the National Register of Citizens (NRC) updated before Manipur's population is counted. Kuki-Zo organisations want the Census first and oppose an NRC based on what they consider an unreliable and potentially exclusionary historical benchmark of 1951 (when the first post-Independence Census was done).

The violence and the Census standoff are rooted in the same unresolved questions over land, migration, citizenship and political representation. At the centre of almost every argument stands the Kuki-Zo population. To the Meitei, the Kuki-Zo question is linked to migration from Myanmar, forest encroachment, poppy cultivation and the demand for a separate administration. To many Naga organisations, it is increasingly about competing claims over the same hills, the expansion of Kuki political territory and control over roads and settlements that Nagas regard as ancestral land.

Kuki-Zo organisations, meanwhile, say Indian Kuki-Zo citizens are being collapsed into a single category with Myanmar and other refugees. They argue that ethnicity can't establish citizenship or criminality.

UNUSUAL CONVERGENCE

The Naga-Kuki conflict of the 1990s, which killed over 700 people, was one of the bloodiest chapters in the state's history. Its causes remain contested, but land and competing territorial projects were central to it. The contest also acquired an economic dimension around Moreh, the strategically located border trading town through which legal and illegal commerce, including narcotics and arms, flowed. The demand for a separate Kuki-Zo administration after 2023 has reignited those old anxieties.

The new Naga-Kuki fault line has also produced an unusual political convergence. Meitei and Naga organisations have historically been adversaries. Naga demands for territorial integration repeatedly collide with Meitei mobilisation to preserve Manipur's existing boundaries. Yet, on the NRC, and increasingly on concerns over Kuki armed groups and migration, the two have found common ground.

This convergence predates the latest violence. In June 2022, the Meitei-based Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity and the United